

Get it correct: Cohen stayed three years

When Andy Cohen, El Paso's "Mr. Baseball," was told his name was mentioned in a Sports Illustrated article on rookie phenoms of the past, he commented, "They probably called me a flash in the pan, didn't they?"

An article accompanying SI's rundown of this year's phenoms in its March 24 issue, headlined "No Ticket To Cooperstown," begins, "Then there are the celebrated rookies who didn't make it . . . Andy Cohen, 1928 Giants, John McGraw's lure for New York's Jews. Pressing under unremitting scrutiny, was sent down after two

seasons."

"Three seasons," corrects Cohen, who served last season as a first-base coach for the El Paso Diablos.

On being a "lure for New York's Jews", Cohen said, "Well, I figure that was part of it because they used to make such a fuss about it in the papers. It was big publicity and, of course, New York was a big Jewish town."

"McGraw was after any kind of good ballplayer and if he was Jewish that only added icing to the cake, see."

"As it turned out ol' Paul Gallico

(a famed New York sports and fiction writer) made a significant remark when I got the gate. He said, 'at least Cohen turned out to be Jewish.'"

Cohen actually was called up in 1926, when Frankie Frisch was the Giants' second baseman, and after "I had my best all-around season in Buffalo in '27," came back in '28, when Rogers Hornsby was at second for the Giants. The next year McGraw traded Hornsby away.

"I hit .274 my first year and .294 my second year. I wasn't the worst ballplayer ever up there. The year I took Hornsby's place, they said

Hornsby went off and left the kid. I hit .294 and he hit .385, I think.

"He not only beat me, but he beat everybody in the whole damn league!"

"So I never felt bad about it, because Hornsby was just the greatest right-handed hitter in the history of baseball."

Cohen says, "I didn't really realize the pressure I was under until I was all through with it. It never occurred to me. I just went out and did the best I could. McGraw was always good to me and he gave me a good chance."